dream, and the beginning of a very important phase in our nation's history. Prof. Satish Dhawan, Chairman ISRO, threw his customary guardedness to the winds and announced that it was now wel within our ability to explore space. Prime Minister Indira Gandhi cabled her congratulations. But the most important reaction was that of the Indian scientific community—everybody was proud of this hundred per cent indigenous effort.

I experienced mixed feelings. I was happy to achieve the success which had been evading me for the past two decades, but I was sad because the people who had inspired me were no longer there to share my joy—my father, my brother-in-law Jal aluddin, and Prof. Sarabhai.

The credit for the successful SLV-3 flight goes, first, to the giants of the Indian space programme, Prof. Sarabhai in particular, who had preceded this effort; next to the hundreds of VSSC personnel who had through sheer wil - power proved the mettle of our countrymen and also, not least, to Prof. Dhawan and Dr Brahm Prakash, who had led the project.

We had a late dinner that evening. Gradual y, the din and clatter of the celebrations calmed down. I retired to my